'A Date Which Will Live in Infamy'

President Franklin D. Roosevelt · Address to Joint Session of Congress · December 8, 1941

Source: U.S. National Archives, archives.gov/historical-docs/todays-doc; FDR Library.

Less than 24 hours after the Japanese surprise attack on Pearl Harbor (December 7, 1941), FDR addressed a joint session of Congress. The original draft began 'a date which will live in world history'; FDR himself penciled in 'infamy.' Within an hour of the speech, Congress voted overwhelmingly (388–1 in the House; 82–0 in the Senate) to declare war on Japan. Germany and Italy declared war on the U.S. three days later.

Connect: WWII gave African Americans and women wartime opportunities that fed into the postwar civil rights and women's movements. Trace ONE line from 1942 to a 1960s development.

Key Passages

Opening

> Yesterday, December 7, 1941 — a date which will live in infamy — the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan.

On the scale of the attack

> Yesterday the Japanese government also launched an attack against Malaya. Last night Japanese forces attacked Hong Kong. Last night Japanese forces attacked Guam. Last night Japanese forces attacked the Philippine Islands. Last night the Japanese attacked Wake Island. And this morning the Japanese attacked Midway Island.

The request

> I ask that the Congress declare that since the unprovoked and dastardly attack by Japan on Sunday, December 7, 1941, a state of war has existed between the United States and the Japanese Empire.

HIPP Analysis

Complete each row using evidence from the passages and your background knowledge.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ — compare two theaters of war: Identify ONE major difference between U.S. operations in the Pacific theater and in the European theater.

2. Why did FDR specifically list each Japanese attack rather than summarize?

3. Identify ONE specific economic or technological development that gave the U.S. an advantage in WWII.